

Kingdom of the Sun

Kingdom of the Sun · Selecting the Final Six (for growth)

Built 2026-06-01. How to pick the last 6 invites to complete the 16-team field in a way that *grows* the tournament, not just fills slots. Decision is BJ's to drive.

Where the field stands

Confirmed 10: Vanguard (host), North Marion, Windermere Prep, P.K. Yonge, Peachtree Ridge (GA), Viera, Tallahassee Godby, Wildwood, Wekiva, South Lake.

Read on the current 10: strong Central/North Florida base + one Georgia program. It's a solid regional field. What it's missing for *growth* is a **marquee name** and a little more **national spread**. That gap is exactly what the final six should fill.

The selection lens (pick for what each slot does)

Don't pick 6 of the same thing. Each invite should do a job:

1. **The Anchor (1-2 slots) — national prestige.** One nationally-known or nationally-ranked program. This is the name that makes the bracket read “national” again and lifts every other team's perceived level. The single highest-leverage invite. Historically the Kingdom drew this caliber (Montverde won here in 2011 before becoming the national #1).
2. **The Returning Champions (1-2 slots) — legacy + storyline.** Recent Kingdom champions coming back. It writes its own narrative (“the 2024 champ returns to defend”), rewards the history, and gives social + press an easy hook. Candidates from the recent roll: St Thomas Aquinas (2024), Winter Haven (2022, 2023), Columbia GA (2019).
3. **The Draw (1-2 slots) — fills the gym.** A program with a big traveling fan base or a natural rivalry with a confirmed team. Bodies in seats on the early nights. Night-one attendance is the sponsor and energy story.
4. **The Spread (1 slot) — keep “national” real.** One more out-of-state program (beyond Peachtree Ridge), ideally from a state with Kingdom history (OH, GA, KY, NJ, DC, TN all have deep roots here; LaSalle OH has played 13 times). Protects the “25+ states, the original national tournament” claim.

A realistic way to run it

You will not land every first choice, so run it like the founder did (he got 16 commitments in 24 hours by working a list, not hoping):

- **Build a ranked target list of ~10-12**, not 6. Tiered by the four jobs above.
- **Invite the Anchor first.** Landing one marquee name makes every other invite easier (“you’d be in the field with ____”).
- **24-hour confirmation discipline.** A verbal that isn’t written by a set date frees the slot for the next target. (Same rule as the coach pipeline.)
- **Keep 3-4 on standby** so a “no” doesn’t stall the field.
- **Lock the field by a hard date** so the bracket and schedule can be built (the site and ops wait on a closed 16).

Realistic target: 6 confirmed from a 10-12 deep list. Aim for at least one Anchor and one Returning Champion in the six. Everything else is a bonus.

What to weigh on each candidate (quick scorecard)

Factor	Why it matters
National name / ranking	Raises the whole field’s level
Kingdom history	Legacy storyline, easy yes
Travel feasibility	Out-of-state needs hotel + willingness
Fan draw / rivalry	Gym attendance, energy, sponsor value
Level fit	Competitive, not a blowout filler

The growth move, stated plainly

The fastest way to grow this tournament back toward its national peak is **one marquee invite that re-anchors it**, surrounded by returning champions and real draws. Six average teams keep it regional. One great team plus five smart ones make it a destination again. Pick for the room you want in five years, not just the 16 slots this year.

Note: specific program names above are candidate targets to pursue, based on the tournament’s own history and the recent champions roll. Confirm current-season fit and willingness before treating any as committed. Log targets in `KOTS_COACH_PIPELINE_OPERATOR.csv` as the field fills.